regimes. While computers are nowhere near their full potential, the same is true of humans. This is something we have discovered again and again throughout history. For example, one of the biggest and most successful transformations in the job market of the twentieth century resulted not from a technological invention but from unleashing the untapped potential of half the human species. To bring women into the job market didn't require any genetic engineering or some other technological wizardry. It required letting go of some outdated myths and enabling women to fulfil the potential they always had.

In the coming decades the economy will likely undergo even bigger upheavals than the massive unemployment of the early 1930s or the entry of women to the job market. The flexibility of democracies, their willingness to question old mythologies and their strong self-correcting mechanism will therefore be crucial assets.[23] Democracies have spent generations cultivating these assets. It would be foolish to abandon them just when we need them most.

UNFATHOMABLE

In order to function, however, democratic self-correcting mechanisms need to understand the things they are supposed to correct. For a dictatorship, being unfathomable is helpful, because it protects the regime from accountability. For a democracy, being unfathomable is deadly. If citizens, lawmakers, journalists and judges cannot understand how the state's bureaucratic system works, they can no longer supervise it, and they lose trust in it.

Despite all the fears and anxieties that bureaucrats have sometimes inspired, prior to the computer age they could never become completely unfathomable, because they always remained human. Regulations, forms and protocols were created by human minds. Officials might be cruel and greedy, but cruelty and greed were familiar human emotions that people could anticipate and manipulate, for example by bribing the officials. Even in a Soviet gulag or a Nazi concentration camp, the bureaucracy wasn't totally alien. Its so-called inhumanity actually reflected human biases and flaws.